



SWEET RETREAT

Chocoholic Sigourney Cantelo heads to a lifestyle retreat and discovers it's possible to detox without really noticing.

It's somewhere between the second chunky Kit Kat and fourth soy latte that I realise I may need a little help. I haven't had a deep, dream-filled sleep for at least two weeks and the only thing getting me through deadline is the promise of pinot – or better, a hot-chip lifeline. When a friend returns, gushing and

glowing, from Gwinganna Lifestyle Retreat at Tallebudgera Valley on Queensland's Gold Coast, the chocolate-covered penny drops. This is what I need – someone to hold my hand while I learn to eat properly, exercise, sleep and dream again. I sign up for Optimal Wellbeing, a five-day program, and jump straight on the next plane.

In the beginning ...

After a 30-minute bus ride from the airport up into the verdant Gold Coast hinterland, myself and 60 other recruits are ushered into

The stunning Signature Villa.

One of the two pools on the property.



orientation. Sharon Kolkka, the genial general manager, welcomes us and explains that over the next five days there will be activities and seminars aimed at optimising health, nutrition, exercise and stress management to help us function at our best. Alcohol, caffeine, processed sugar and even perfume (it can cause allergies) are contraband but, unlike the fat camps of the 1980s, nothing is compulsory and the healthy food is delicious and plentiful. The use of mobile phones is discouraged (some rooms have reception or you can climb the cricket stand on the oval).

We are then given little cards with our spa appointment times – I have a *ka huna* massage at 4pm. This, Kolkka explains, is how we will learn of each day's events: there are no schedules, so we are forced to be present and take each day as it comes. Then we meet with a nutritionist to go through dietary requirements and dislikes (yes, the kitchen can omit raw onion from my meals) and do a zinc test, where you swill a zinc solution in your mouth. If it tastes okay, you have

failed – it means you're low in zinc, a stress- and disease-fighting mineral. It tastes like water to me.

Next up is a quick, painless fitness assessment (no treadmills or fat pincers in sight), which looks at posture, breathing and any aches or niggles. My tense shoulders have me standing a bit like Quasimodo, but it's apparently nothing a little yoga and massage can't fix.

Then it's off to the rooms to unpack. I'm in one of two Signature Villas: a luxe, cavernous Asian-themed pavilion with a private steam room centred around

a delicious four-poster bed and stone bath overlooking a tranquil, tree-lined billabong. I don't want to leave, but it's nearly time for my treatment, so I head to the spa to explore. The whole 1,500 square metres of reclaimed timber structure radiates from a circular walkway (symbolising perfection and purity) around three towering eucalypts.

The treatment rooms (there are 33) look out to untamed scrub, and all the water used is collected from run-off from the roof. Paie, my therapist, finds me and leads me to my room. She explains that this Hawaiian form of massage, also known as *lomi lomi*, is traditionally done in the nude (with some modesty-saving towel draping) to allow long fluid movements that slide up and down the sides of the body. I strip down and within minutes I've fallen under the spell of the rhythmic, oil-slicked strokes, a massage balm that smells like tropical flowers and coconut, and lilting Hawaiian music. When I come to from my deep alpha state, I realise I'm drooling through the hole in the massage bed. Now that's relaxation. Tomorrow, the program begins.

And then there was light ...

It's 5.30am and I'm blinking awake at the brilliant sunshine on a hillside overlooking an impossibly green valley, wondering how I got here. Our program manager Donna, who looks like she has wheatgrass juice pumping through her veins, leads us through *qigong* (a form of *tai chi*), and then we're off on a heart-starting walk through stunning subtropical bushland.

Before breakfast we do shots of apple cider vinegar (to improve acidity in our stomach and aid digestion), before indulging in poached eggs on sourdough toast. Donna tells us a registered nurse and naturopath is on hand to distribute magnesium for anyone suffering detox headaches. I feel okay, but I'd give my firstborn for a cheeky Freddo. I head to yoga in the open-air pavilion, despite a sprinkling, and find it's beautiful to practise with the gentle rain on the leaves and the trill of rosellas and king parrots. By the end I feel Zened out and totally refreshed.

A morning tea of banana smoothies is followed by a seminar with Dr Karen Coates about preventative health. It's fascinating and I'm not-taking like I'm at uni again. Among other things, I learn that the stress hormone cortisol activates abnormal cells, like cancerous cells; that you can decrease your risk of a stroke or a heart attack by 24 per cent if you take one milligram of folic

acid every day; and that mercury in fish has been shown to cause dementia – so stick to small fish, and skip the flake and swordfish. By the end of the seminar I'm pledging allegiance to organic food (so many more nutrients) and swearing to never use my mobile phone without the hands-free kit again, to prevent brain cancer.

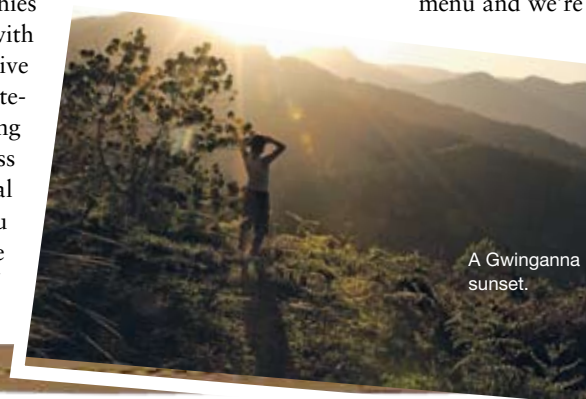
Lunch is a delicious salad and soup affair and then we are free to relax for the afternoon, a period known as “dream time”, where we have treatments or just rest, read and write. I head back to the spa for 80 minutes of myotherapy, where you are massaged in gentle yoga stretches. It's heaven. My therapist Josh's nimble fingers delve deep into my knottiest nooks and crannies and I emerge feeling stretched, smoothed out and about five centimetres taller. Quasimodo has left the building – I'm walking like a gymnast.

I float in a happy stupor to dinner where, at communal tables, we get to know our fellow retreaters. It's a real melting pot. There are gym junkies and couch potatoes, mother-and-daughter duos, wives with disgruntled husbands, and more than a few women trying to quell the middle-age spread. Everyone is friendly and talkative, united in the common goal of a healthier existence. Many guests are on their second or third visit, and one well-known property developer actually lives here for a month a few times a year.

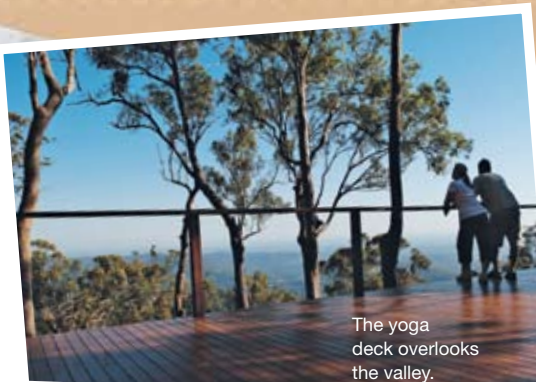
As we eat, we are encouraged to chew each mouthful 20 times and are advised not to drink water with our meals. This helps the enzymes in our saliva digest our food and also gives the stomach time to send a message to the brain to tell us when we are full. It works – after half a bowl of vegetable curry, I'm done. By 9pm I fall onto my feather-soft bed and into a deep, dreamy sleep.

The last supper ...

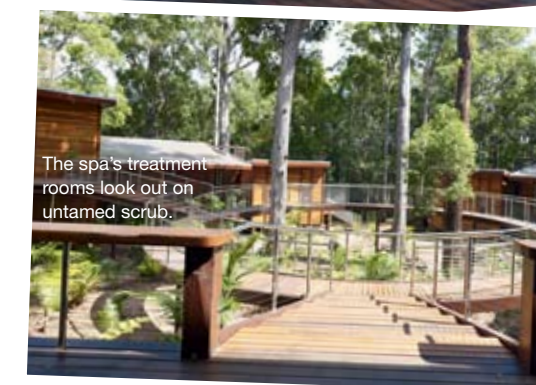
Five days go by in a blur of invigorating bushwalks, entertaining activities (belly dancing, anyone?) and incredible treatments, and suddenly it's the eve of our last day. We are gathered around for a special dinner – fillet steak with vegetable rosti is on the menu and we're



A Gwinganna sunset.



The yoga deck overlooks the valley.



The spa's treatment rooms look out on untamed scrub.

allowed a tiny glass of organic wine. The mood in the dining room is electric. Everyone is swapping phone numbers and the air is filled with laughter. I have made some lovely friends and achieved so much that I can barely believe it. In a few short days I've learnt the ancient art of *qigong*, conquered the most challenging bushwalk of the week (the Caroda trail), danced with childlike abandon in a tribal dance session, learnt how to plant a herb garden with resident green thumb Shelley, and how to deliciously prepare the produce during an organic cooking lesson with gentle Austrian chef Hermann. I'm brimming with ideas on how to incorporate all I've learnt into daily life and I can't wait to get home and turn over my bright new leaf.

And then something very strange happens. I am given my glass of wine and I don't feel like drinking it. Come to think of it, I haven't had a single Cadbury-based thought since Tuesday. I haven't even been tired enough to want coffee. It dawns on me that I don't need these things in my life, and when I don't have them I feel really, really good.

Revelations

I took so much home with me from the health retreat: ways to eat better, sleep more soundly, exercise smarter and stress less. I've been working out most days, I've quit caffeine and I haven't made a single visit to the vending machine in the two weeks I've been back. It wasn't hard. All I needed was some hand-holding and a little push in the right direction. Now I'm the one who's glowing and gushing about Gwinganna. ■

Five-night Optimal Wellbeing packages start at \$2,075 per person. For more information, visit www.gwinganna.com.au.